
Appendix 4 of ‘XJTLU Policy on Ethical Conduct in Research’

Participant Information Sheet Guidelines

[Note: These guidelines have been adapted from those in use at the University of Liverpool]

The informed consent process requires that prospective participants are provided with as much information as possible about a research project in order that they, and / or their legal guardians / advocates, can make an ‘informed decision’ about whether or not they want to take part in the project.

Information sheets, normally provided in written format but can also be spoken, are an important part of the informed consent process. With this in mind, this document has been produced to act as guidance for staff and students when designing their information sheets. If you have any questions about this document, please contact the Chair of the University Research Ethics Review Panel at XJTLU at ethics@xjtlu.edu.cn.

General Information

The design of your information sheet should reflect the nature of the research study. Some information sheets may therefore need to be a little more detailed than others, or may use graphics rather than just text. Clearly, the information sheet should be in a language that is readily comprehensible to the prospective participant. Thus, it may be necessary to translate the information into Mandarin or another language.

It is important to make sure that even after the information sheet has been read and consent has been obtained, the participant has the right to ask any further questions and they should be provided with details on where to find further appropriate information on the specific research area.

All protocols and supporting documents, including information sheets and consent forms, should state the version number and date of the document. The date indicates when the documentation was finalised. Version numbers and dates show how a document was developed, help to identify earlier versions if required, and act as an aid to monitoring and audit.

Please note:

- If an amendment to a document is made, the version number and date must also be amended.
- Failure to include them will slow up the approval process as they will be sent back to the researcher for amendment.

It is essential that any logos, project titles, version numbers, dates, contact details, etc. are consistent across documents, and that a record of the changes to documents is logged through version numbers and dates for each document.

The first page of the information sheet (and all corresponding documents) should have the University Logo at the top in the centre.

You may need to make provision for participants who are not fluent in the language used in the information sheet and should consider how to deal with problems such as illiteracy. For example, you may choose to have an interpreter / translator to hand for participants who may not be fluent in the language used.



Studies involving children / vulnerable adults: you may need to consider producing an alternative version of the information sheet which is more accessible and which can be discussed with the legal guardian (e.g. parent, guardian, caregiver, etc.). This alternative version should, however, conform to the same purpose as other information sheets in that its aim is to provide enough information and in appropriate detail so that informed consent can be obtained.

Recommended sections to include in your Participant Information Sheet

1. Title of Research Project and Researcher(s)

Your study title should be the same on all related documents and should explain the study in simple English. If you have used a short title, make sure that you quote this as well as the full title on your ethics application form.

You should provide the list of researchers (including title and affiliation). It must match the list of researchers on the informed consent form(s) and on the ethics application form. The Principal Investigator should be listed first and clearly identified as such. If the Principal Investigator is a student, the Supervisor should also be listed and clearly identified as such.

2. Version Number and Date

All information sheets should have a version number and date that is consistent with all corresponding documents (e.g. study plan / protocol, consent form, etc.). This is a way of determining which version of the documentation participants have received should any queries arise.

3. Invitation Paragraph

Invite the participant to take part in the study and be careful to make sure that it does not sound as if they are being pressured or coerced. For example:

You are being invited to participate in a research study. Before you decide whether to participate, it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what it will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully and feel free to ask us if you would like more information or if there is anything that you do not understand. Please also feel free to discuss this with your friends, relatives, and doctor [where relevant] if you wish. We would like to stress that you do not have to accept this invitation and should only agree to take part if you want to.

Thank you for reading this.

4. What is the purpose of the study?

In simple terms, with all technical terms and acronyms defined, you should explain why the study is being done, e.g. the background, aims and objectives, etc.

If it is not appropriate to inform participants of the purpose of the research at this stage, for example in the case where this may affect the behaviour of participants, please ensure that participants are fully debriefed at the end of the research. Please also enclose a debriefing form with your application for ethics.

5. Why have I been chosen to take part?

Briefly explain the reasons why and how you have chosen to invite participants and also how many others will be taking part.

6. Do I have to take part?

It should be made clear that participation is voluntary and that participants are free to withdraw their participation at any time, without explanation, and without incurring a disadvantage.

7. What will happen if I take part?

In simple terms, you should provide an explanation of exactly what will be asked of the participant and what will happen during the research. For example, you should explain clearly:

- what the methods are
- who the researchers are
- who will be carrying out the procedure
- what the duration / frequency of the procedure is
- what the participant's responsibilities are

When writing this section, think about what details you would want to know if you were to take part in a research study.

Information should be displayed in an appropriate format for the population involved in the research, for example, pictorial / diagram / oral format rather than text may be more suitable for some.

Participants should be made aware if research involves any audio / visual recording and this should be made clear in both the information sheet and consent form.

Please note that if there is a possibility that the participant's doctor may need to be contacted, this should also be made clear in the information sheet and consent form.

8. How will my data be used?

You must inform the participant of the lawful basis for processing their personal data – and if special category data or criminal offence data will be collected, you will need to outline the condition of processing as well as the lawful basis (please refer to the 'Data Security Law of the People's Republic of China' [中华人民共和国数据安全法] and the 'Personal Information Protection Law of the People's Republic of China' [中华人民共和国个人信息保护法] for further guidance on the lawful basis for processing).

You should use the following wording to inform participants of the lawful basis on which the University processes personal data in research and to inform them of how their data will be used:

The University processes personal data as part of its research and teaching activities in accordance with the lawful basis of public task, and in accordance



with the University's purpose of advancing education, learning and research for the public benefit.

Under the 'Data Security Law of the People's Republic of China' (中华人民共和国数据安全法) and the 'Personal Information Protection Law of the People's Republic of China' (中华人民共和国个人信息保护法), the University acts as the Data Controller for personal data collected as part of the University's research. The [Principal Investigator / Supervisor] acts as the Data Processor for this study, and any queries relating to the handling of your personal data can be sent to [Principal Investigator / Supervisor contact details].

Further information on how your data will be used can be found in the table below.

How will my data be collected?	
How will my data be stored?	
How long will my data be stored for?	
What measures are in place to protect the security and confidentiality of my data?	
Will my data be anonymised?	
How will my data be used?	
Who will have access to my data?	
Will my data be archived for use in other research projects in the future?	
How will my data be destroyed?	

Transferring data outside China

If personal data will be transferred outside China, you must explain how this will be conducted, why this is necessary, and outline the safeguards in place to protect the data.

9. Expenses and / or payments

Detail any expenses that might be available (e.g. for travel, refreshments, etc.) and any reimbursement, compensation, or incentives that participants may be eligible for.

10. Are there any risks in taking part?

Please explain whether there are any perceived disadvantages or risks involved. Explain that if the participant should experience any discomfort or disadvantage as part of the research that this should be made known to the researcher(s) immediately.

Certain areas of research may have the potential for identifying a serious risk to the participant or to others. For example, this might relate to the identification of a medical condition, financial concerns (e.g. severe debt), legal concerns, etc. If you believe your research could identify such risks you should



provide details in your information sheet of advice and resources; and details of any procedures that will be followed.

For example:

- a) in the event of discovering a medical risk, you may advise that information collected may be referred to an appropriate medical practitioner for examination
- b) if you are studying consumer behaviour / spending behaviour might include a section in the information sheet which gives the details of appropriate local / national / international agencies so that participants may contact them if they want further advice on debt.
- c) if your research involves studying smoking or alcohol use, you could offer details of local / national / international agencies.

11. Are there any benefits in taking part?

Any benefits (at the time of participation or in the future) should be explained. If there is no intended benefit this should be made clear.

12. What will happen to the results of the study?

Detail how the results will be made available to the participants and whether the results are to be published. If the results are to be published, detail how and where they will be accessible. Tell participants that they will not be identifiable from the results unless they have consented to being so.

13. What will happen if I want to stop taking part?

Participants should be informed that they can withdraw their participation in the study at any time, without explanation.

Results up to the period of withdrawal may be used, if participants are happy for this to be done. Otherwise, participants may request that the results are destroyed and no further use is made of them. If results are anonymised, you should make clear that results may only be withdrawn prior to anonymisation.

You should provide details of how participants can withdraw their information, explain who should be contacted, and explain any limitations on the withdrawal of information (for example, if the data have been fully anonymised).

14. What if I am unhappy or if there is a problem?

All complaints should be handled through the University Research Ethics Review Panel complaints procedure. You should use something similar to the following to explain how complaints will be handled:

If you are unhappy, or if there is a problem, please feel free to let us know by contacting [Principal Investigator / Supervisor contact details] and we will try to help. If you remain unhappy or have a complaint which you feel you cannot come to us with then you should contact the Chair of the University Research Ethics Review Panel at ethics@xjtlu.edu.cn. When contacting the University Research Ethics Review Panel administrators, please



provide details of the name or description of the study (so that it can be identified), the researcher(s) involved, and the details of the complaint you wish to make.

15. Who can I contact if I have further questions?

You should give the name, address, and contact telephone number of the Principal Investigator / Supervisor.

16. Thanks

You should put a note of thanks to participants.

Optional sections (choose as appropriate)

Discussing sensitive or distressing topics

If the research involves the potential disclosure of personal and sensitive information, you should explain the risk of potential emotional distress, and you should emphasise that participants can abstain from answering any questions they may be uncomfortable with.

You should explain the procedure in place to manage a situation where participant distress occurs (for example, pausing the interview to provide time for participants to consider whether to continue or withdraw from the study).

Health related findings in research

Some health-related studies may involve the collection of data which can reveal significant unexpected abnormalities, which require medical follow-up, either for further investigation or (more rarely) treatment.

You should explain to participants that the data is being collected for research purposes, and state whether you propose to review the data for potential health related findings in research. If so, you should explain the procedure in the event that a significant health related abnormality is found, including whether you will send a report to the participant's doctor. It should be emphasised that participation in the study is not a substitute for a 'health check'.

Disclosure of criminal activity

If you are carrying out research where you may collect information with the potential for disclosure of serious criminal activity (e.g. research with young offenders / prisoners) **you should inform participants that confidentiality may not always be assured**. Please also ensure that you have discussed with the appropriate authorities a reporting procedure to follow if such information is disclosed.